

# Independent Reading

## Grade 8

Students entering grade 8 are expected to read at least **two independent reading books**. Students are encouraged to choose from the suggested titles on the pages that follow. In the event that a student wishes to make an alternate selection, we ask that families take an active role in helping students select an appropriate independent reading title.

For other suggestions, please check out [YALSA's book awards and book lists](#) for a selection of award-winning titles.

*Note: Students will discuss their independent reading selections in September—There is no written requirement.*



### Please Note:

Many books on our independent reading list are available as eBooks through [FollettShelf](#) or the [Sora](#) app. Titles with an active hyperlink are available as eBooks. Students should use their school username and password to access the site. Contact [bbarthelmes@byramhills.org](mailto:bbarthelmes@byramhills.org) with any questions about using eBooks.

*Quantities are limited*



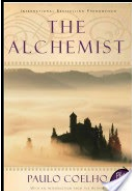
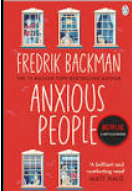
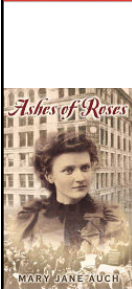
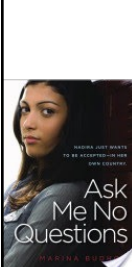
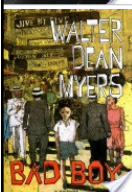
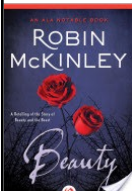
Challenging Read



For the Reluctant Reader

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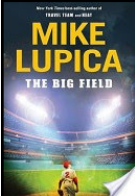
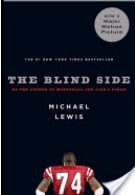
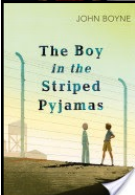
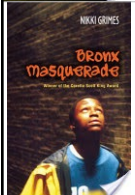
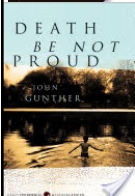
| Suggested Titles                                                                    |                                                                                                                  |                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
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|    | <b><u>The Alchemist</u></b><br> | Paulo Coelho      | <i>The Alchemist</i> is the magical story of Santiago, an Andalusian shepherd boy who yearns to travel in search of a worldly treasure as extravagant as any ever found. From his home in Spain he journeys to the markets of Tangiers and across the Egyptian desert to a fateful encounter with the alchemist.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|    | <b><u>Anxious People</u></b>                                                                                     | Fredrik Backman   | Looking at real estate isn't usually a life-or-death situation, but an apartment open house becomes just that when a failed bank robber bursts in and takes a group of strangers hostage.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|   | <b><u>Ashes of Roses</u></b>                                                                                     | Mary Jane Auch    | 16 year old Rose and her family come from Ireland to make their fortune in America. Her father and baby brother are forced to return to Ireland, leaving her, her mother, and sisters in America. They struggle with staying with family that were not expecting them and are not very welcoming. When things blow up between them and their American family, her mother decides it's time to return to Ireland. Rose and her 12 year old sister, Maureen, refuse to go and cash in their ticket to stay in America. Life is more difficult than they could ever imagine. Just as things finally start getting better, tragedy strikes. Rose is working as a seamstress at a factory when it catches on fire. She loses all her new friends and her job to the fire. |
|  | <b><u>Ask me No Questions</u></b>                                                                                | Marina Budhos     | Since emigrating from Bangladesh, fourteen-year-old Nadira and her family have been living in New York City on expired visas, hoping to realize their dream of becoming legal U.S. citizens. But after 9/11, everything changes. Suddenly being Muslim means you are dangerous -- a suspected terrorist.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|  | <b><u>Bad Boy</u></b><br>     | Walter Dean Myers | In a memoir that is gripping, funny, and ultimately unforgettable, New York Times bestselling author Walter Dean Myers travels back to his roots in the magical world of Harlem during the 1940s and 1950s. Here is the story of one of the most distinguished writers of young people's literature today.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|  | <b><u>Beauty—A Retelling of Beauty and the Beast</u></b>                                                         | Robin McKinley    | Robin McKinley's acclaimed first novel is a brilliant reimagining of the classic French fairy tale                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

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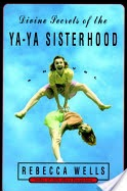
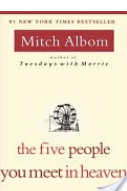
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|    | <b><u>The Big Field</u></b><br>😊             | Mike Lupica     | Playing shortstop is a way of life for Hutch. Not only is his hero, Derek Jeter, a shortstop, but so was his father, a former local legend turned pro. Which is why having to play second base feels like demotion to second team. Yet that's where Hutch ends up after Darryl "D-Will" Williams, the best shortstop prospect since A-Rod, joins the team.                         |
|    | <b><u>The Blind Side</u></b><br>🎯            | Michael Lewis   | When we first meet Michael Oher, he is one of thirteen children by a mother addicted to crack; he does not know his real name, his father, his birthday, or how to read or write. He takes up football, and school, after a rich, white, Evangelical family plucks him from the streets.                                                                                           |
|   | <b><u>The Boy in the Striped Pyjamas</u></b> | John Boyne      | Nine-year-old Bruno has a lot of things on his mind. Who is the 'Fury'? Why did he make them leave their nice home in Berlin to go to 'Out-With' ? And who are all the sad people in striped pyjamas on the other side of the fence? The grown-ups won't explain so Bruno decides there is only one thing for it - he will have to explore this place alone.                       |
|  | <b><u>Bronx Masquerade</u></b><br>😊          | Nikki Grimes    | Using the structure of a poetry slam, Nikki Grimes' award-winning novel is a powerful exploration of self, an homage to spoken-word poetry, and an intriguing look into the life of eighteen urban teens.                                                                                                                                                                          |
|  | <b><u>Chinese Cinderella</u></b>             | Adeline Yen Mah | A riveting memoir of a girl's painful coming-of-age in a wealthy Chinese family during the 1940s. Students are also welcome to read the sequel, <i>Falling Leaves</i> .                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|  | <b><u>Death Be Not Proud</u></b><br>🎯        | John Gunther    | Johnny Gunther was only seventeen years old when he died of a brain tumor. During the months of his illness, everyone near him was unforgettably impressed by his level-headed courage, his wit and quiet friendliness, and, above all, his unfaltering patience through times of despair. This deeply moving book is a father's memoir of a brave, intelligent, and spirited boy. |
|  | <b><u>Divergent</u></b>                      | Veronica Roth   | Perfect for fans of the <i>Hunger Games</i> and <i>Maze Runner</i> series, <i>Divergent</i> and its sequels, <i>Insurgent</i> and <i>Allegiant</i> , are the gripping story of a dystopian world transformed by courage, self-sacrifice, and love.                                                                                                                                 |

🎯 Challenging Read

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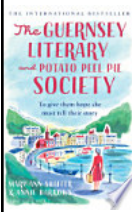
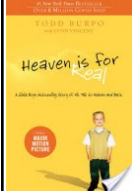
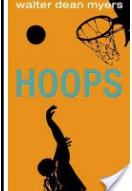
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|    | <b><u>The Divine Secrets of the Ya-Ya Sisterhood</u></b><br> | Rebecca Wells       | When theatre director Siddalee Walker inadvertently reveals some of the less-savory facts of her Louisiana childhood to the New York Times, the article brands her mother, Vivi, a "tap-dancing child abuser." Vivi virtually disowns Sidda, but the Ya-Yas sashay in and conspire to bring everybody back together.                                                                                                                                                |
|    | <b><u>Don't Breathe A Word</u></b>                                                                                                            | Jordyn Taylor       | Eva has never felt like she belonged . . . not in her own family or with her friends in New York City, and certainly not at a fancy boarding school like Hardwick Preparatory Academy. So, when she is invited to join the Fives, an elite secret society, she jumps at the opportunity to finally be a part of something.                                                                                                                                          |
|   | <b><u>Ear, the Eye, and the Arm</u></b>                                                                                                       | Nancy Farmer        | Tendai, his little sister and their younger brother escape from their splendid home to explore their dangerous city. Tendai is motivated by wanting to earn a scouting badge, and he desperately wants to prove himself, as their overprotective father has always placed tight restrictions on what the siblings can and can't do.                                                                                                                                 |
|  | <b><u>Eragon</u></b>                                                                                                                          | Christopher Paolini | Fifteen-year-old Eragon believes that he is merely a poor farm boy--until his destiny as a Dragon Rider is revealed. Gifted with only an ancient sword, a loyal dragon, and sage advice from an old storyteller, Eragon is soon swept into a dangerous tapestry of magic, glory, and power. Now his choices could save--or destroy--the Empire.                                                                                                                     |
|  | <b><u>The Five People You Meet in Heaven</u></b>                                                                                              | Mitch Albom         | Eddie is a wounded war veteran, an old man who has lived, in his mind, an uninspired life. His job is fixing rides at a seaside amusement park. On his 83rd birthday, a tragic accident kills him, as he tries to save a little girl from a falling cart. He awakes in the afterlife, where he learns that heaven is not a destination. It's a place where your life is explained to you by five people, some of whom you knew, others who may have been strangers. |
|  | <b><u>Freak the Mighty</u></b><br>                         | Rodman Philbrick    | Two boys – a slow learner stuck in the body of a teenage giant and a tiny Einstein in leg braces – forge a unique friendship when they pair up to create one formidable human force.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|  | <b><u>Graceling</u></b>                                                                                                                       | Kristin Cashore     | In a world where some people are born with extreme and often-feared skills called Graces, Katsa struggles for redemption from her own horrifying Grace, the Grace of killing, and teams up with another young fighter to save their land from a corrupt king                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

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|    | <b><i>The Guernsey Literary and Potato Peel Society</i></b> | Mary Ann Shaffer & Annie Barrows | It's 1946. The war is over, and Juliet Ashton has writer's block. But when she receives a letter from Dawsey Adams of Guernsey – a total stranger living halfway across the Channel, who has come across her name written in a second hand book – she enters into a correspondence with him, and in time with all the members of the extraordinary Guernsey Literary and Potato Peel Pie Society. |
|    | <b><i>Handbook for Dragon Slayers</i></b>                   | Merrie Haskell                   | Yearning for life in a cloistered scriptorium, thirteen-year-old Princess Matilda, whose lame foot brings fear of the evil eye, escapes her scheming cousin Ivo and joins her servant Judith and an old friend, Parz, in hunting dragons and writing about them.                                                                                                                                  |
|   | <b><i>Heat</i></b><br>😊                                     | Mike Lupica                      | Pitching prodigy Michael Arroyo is on the run from social services after being banned from playing Little League baseball because rival coaches doubt he is only twelve years old and he has no parents to offer them proof.                                                                                                                                                                      |
|  | <b><i>Heaven is for Real</i></b>                            | Todd Burpo and Lynn Vincent      | Presents the story of the four-year old son of a Nebraska pastor who during emergency surgery slips from consciousness and enters heaven.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|  | <b><i>Hoops</i></b><br>😊                                    | Walter Dean Myers                | All eyes are on seventeen-year-old Lonnie Jackson while he practices with his team for a city-wide basketball Tournament of Champions. His coach, Cal, knows Lonnie has what it takes to be a pro-basketball player, but warns him about giving in to the pressure. Cal knows because he, too, once had the chance--but sold out.                                                                 |
|  | <b><i>The Host</i></b>                                      | Stephenie Meyer                  | A member of a species that takes over the minds of human bodies, Wanderer is unable to disregard his host's love for a man in hiding, a situation that forces both possessor and host to become unwilling allies.                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|  | <b><i>The House on Mango Street</i></b>                     | Sandra Cisneros                  | Told in a series of vignettes—sometimes heartbreaking, sometimes joyous—Cisneros's masterpiece is a classic story of childhood and self-discovery and one of the greatest neighborhood novels of all time.                                                                                                                                                                                        |

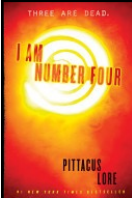
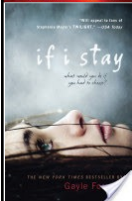
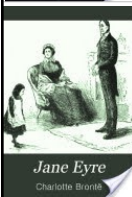
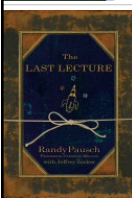
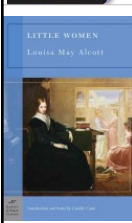
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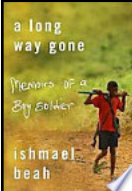
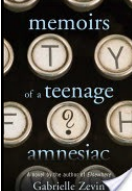
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|    | <b>Any book in the <i>I am Number Four</i> series</b><br> | Pittacus Lore     | In rural Ohio, friendships and a beautiful girl prove distracting to a fifteen-year-old who has hidden on Earth for ten years waiting to develop the Legacies, or powers, he will need to rejoin the other six surviving Garde members and fight the Mogadorians who destroyed their planet, Lorien.                                                                                                      |
|    | <b><i>If I Stay</i></b>                                                                                                                    | Gayle Forman      | While in a coma following an automobile accident that killed her parents and younger brother, seventeen-year-old Mia, a gifted cellist, weighs whether to live with her grief or join her family in death.                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|   | <b><i>Jane Eyre</i></b><br>                               | Charlotte Bronte  | In early nineteenth-century England, an orphaned young woman accepts employment as a governess at Thornfield Hall, a country estate owned by the mysteriously remote Mr. Rochester.                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|  | <b><i>The Last Lecture</i></b>                                                                                                             | Randy Pausch      | Reflections of a Carnegie Mellon computer science professor who lectured on "Really achieving your childhood dreams," shortly after having been diagnosed with terminal cancer. His advice concerned seizing the moment while living, rather than dying.                                                                                                                                                  |
|  | <b><i>Little Altars Everywhere</i></b><br>              | Rebecca Wells     | The companion to the beloved bestseller <i>Divine Secrets of the Ya-Ya Sisterhood</i> , here is the funny, heartbreaking, and powerfully insightful tale that first introduced Siddalee, Vivi, their spirited Walker clan, and the indomitable Ya-Yas.                                                                                                                                                    |
|  | <b><i>Little Women</i></b>                                                                                                                 | Louisa May Alcott | Generations of readers young and old, male and female, have fallen in love with the March sisters of Louisa May Alcott's most popular and enduring novel, <i>Little Women</i> . Here are talented tomboy and author-to-be Jo, tragically frail Beth, beautiful Meg, and romantic, spoiled Amy, united in their devotion to each other and their struggles to survive in New England during the Civil War. |
|  | <b><i>Long Shot</i></b><br>                             | Mike Lupica       | Pedro, an avid basketball player, decides to run for class president, challenging a teammate who is also one of the most popular boys in school.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

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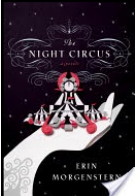
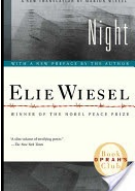
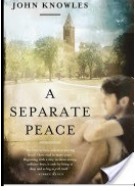
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|    | <b><u>A Long Way Gone: Memoirs of a Boy Soldier</u></b>                               | Ishmael Beah    | By thirteen, he'd been picked up by the government army, and Beah, at heart a gentle boy, found that he was capable of truly terrible acts. This is a rare and mesmerizing account, told with real literary force and heartbreaking honesty.                                                                                                                                               |
|    | <b><u>Memoirs of a Teenage Amnesiac</u></b>                                           | Gabrielle Zevin | After a nasty fall, Naomi realizes that she has no memory of the last four years and finds herself reassessing every aspect of her life.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|   | <b><u>Miracle on 49th Street</u></b><br>😊                                             | Mike Lupica     | After her mother's death, twelve-year-old Molly learns that her father is a basketball star for the Boston Celtics.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|  | <b><u>Miss Peregrine's Home for Peculiar Children</u></b>                             | Ransom Riggs    | After a family tragedy, Jacob feels compelled to explore an abandoned orphanage on an island off the coast of Wales, discovering disturbing facts about the children who were kept there.                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|  | <b><u>My Grandmother Asked Me to Tell You She's Sorry</u></b>                         | Fredrik Backman | Elsa is seven years old and different. Her grandmother is seventy-seven years old and crazy—as in standing-on-the-balcony-firing-paintball-guns-at-strangers crazy. She is also Elsa's best, and only, friend. At night Elsa takes refuge in her grandmother's stories, in the Land-of-Almost-Awake and the Kingdom of Miamas, where everybody is different and nobody needs to be normal. |
|  | <b><u>NERDS: National Espionage, Rescue, and Defense Society (Books 1-5)</u></b><br>😊 | Michael Buckley | While running a spy network from their elementary school, five socially awkward misfits combine their talents and use cutting-edge gadgetry to fight evil around the world.<br><u>M is for Mama's Boy</u><br><u>The Cheerleaders of Doom</u><br><u>The Villain Virus</u><br><u>Attack of the Bullies</u>                                                                                   |

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|    | <b><u>The Night Circus</u></b><br>   | Erin Morgenstern | In this mesmerizing debut, a competition between two magicians becomes a star-crossed love story.                                                                                                                                                         |
|    | <b><u>Night</u></b>                                                                                                   | Elie Wiesel      | <i>Night</i> is Elie Wiesel's masterpiece, a candid, horrific, and deeply poignant autobiographical account of his survival as a teenager in the Nazi death camps.                                                                                        |
|   | <b><u>One of Us is Lying</u></b>                                                                                      | Karen McManus    | <i>The Breakfast Club</i> meets <i>Pretty Little Liars</i> , <i>One of Us is Lying</i> is the story of what happens when five strangers walk into detention and only four walk out alive. Everyone is a suspect, and everyone has something to hide.      |
|  | <b><u>Pills and Starships</u></b>                                                                                     | Lydia Millet     | Lydia Millet's first YA novel explores a world devastated by global warming, and two teenagers determined to survive against all.                                                                                                                         |
|  | <b><u>The Princess Curse</u></b>                                                                                      | Merrie Haskell   | Merrie Haskell's middle-grade fantasy novel <i>The Princess Curse</i> is an imaginative retelling of the fairy tales <i>The Twelve Dancing Princesses</i> and <i>Beauty and the Beast</i> .                                                               |
|  | <b><u>See You in the Cosmos</u></b>                                                                                   | Jack Cheng       | A space-obsessed boy and his dog, Carl Sagan, take a journey toward family, love, hope, and awe in this funny and moving novel for fans of <i>Counting by 7s</i> , <i>Walk Two Moons</i> , and <i>The Curious Incident of the Dog in the Night-Time</i> . |
|  | <b><u>A Separate Peace</u></b><br> | John Knowles     | An American classic and great bestseller for over thirty years, <i>A Separate Peace</i> is timeless in its description of adolescence during a period when the entire country was losing its innocence to the second world war.                           |

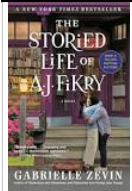
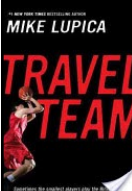
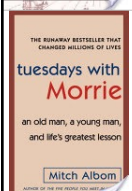
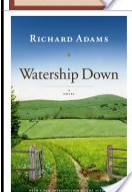
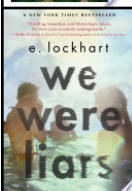
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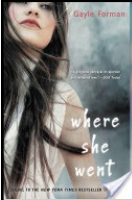
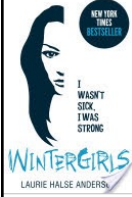
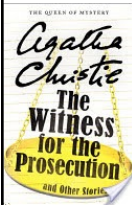
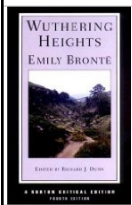
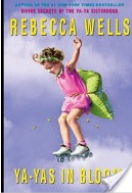
| Suggested Titles                                                                    |                                              |                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | <b><i>The Storied Life of A.J. Fikry</i></b> | Gabrielle Zevin        | An irresistible novel about second chances and finding room for all the books—and all the love—that transform our lives.                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|    | <b><i>The Time Keeper</i></b>                | Mitch Albom            | From the author who's inspired millions worldwide with books like <i>Tuesdays with Morrie</i> and <i>The Five People You Meet in Heaven</i> comes his most imaginative novel yet, <i>The Time Keeper</i> --a compelling fable about the first man on earth to count the hours. The man who became Father Time.          |
|   | <b><i>Travel Team</i></b><br>😊               | Mike Lupica            | After he is cut from his travel basketball team--the very same team that his father once led to national prominence--twelve-year-old Danny Walker forms his own team of cast-offs that might have a shot at victory.                                                                                                    |
|  | <b><i>Treasure Island</i></b><br>🎯           | Robert Lewis Stevenson | An innkeeper's son finds a treasure map that leads him to a pirate's fortune.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|  | <b><i>Tuesdays with Morrie</i></b>           | Mitch Albom            | When he learns that his former college professor is dying, Mitch, a busy sports journalist, makes time to visit him and finds his own outlook on life changed by his conversations with the dying teacher.                                                                                                              |
|  | <b><i>Watership Down</i></b>                 | Richard Adams          | Chronicles the adventures of a group of rabbits searching for a safe place to establish a new warren where they can live in peace.                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|  | <b><i>We Were Liars</i></b>                  | E. Lockhart            | A beautiful and distinguished family. A private island. A brilliant, damaged girl; a passionate, political boy. A group of four friends—the Liars—whose friendship turns destructive. A revolution. An accident. A secret. Lies upon lies. True love. The truth. Read it. And if anyone asks you how it ends, just LIE. |

🎯 Challenging Read

😊 For the Reluctant Reader

# Independent Reading

## Grade 8

| Suggested Titles                                                                    |                                                                                                                        |                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    | <b><u>Where She Went</u></b>                                                                                           | Gayle Forman          | It's been three years since Mia walked out of Adam's life. And three years he's spent wondering why. When their paths cross again in New York, Adam and Mia are brought back together for one life-changing night. Adam finally has the opportunity to ask Mia the questions that have been haunting him.                                                                                                    |
|    | <b><u>Wintergirls</u></b>                                                                                              | Laurie Halse Anderson | A beautifully written and riveting look at anorexia from acclaimed author Laurie Halse Anderson. Cassie and Lia are best friends, and united in their quest to be thin. But when Cassie is found dead in a motel room, Lia must question whether she continues to lose weight, or choose life instead.                                                                                                       |
|   | <b><u>The Witness for the Prosecution, and other Stories</u></b>                                                       | Agatha Christie       | A murder trial takes a diabolical turn when the wife of the accused takes the stand. . . . A woman's sixth sense—and a loaded revolver—signal premonitions of doom. . . . A stranded motorist seeks refuge in a remote mansion and is greeted with a dire warning. . . . Detective Hercule Poirot faces his greatest challenge when his services are enlisted—by the victim—in a bizarre locked-room murder. |
|  | <b><u>Wuthering Heights</u></b><br> | Emily Bronte          | In 19th century Yorkshire, the passionate attachment between a headstrong young girl and a foundling boy brought up by her father causes disaster for them and many others, even in the next generation.                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|  | <b><u>Ya-Yas in Bloom</u></b><br>   | Rebecca Wells         | Rebecca Wells's wonderful third book in her Ya-Ya trilogy, which includes <i>Little Altars Everywhere</i> and <i>Divine Secrets of the Ya-Ya Sisterhood</i> , is sure to provide reading that makes you laugh and cry, a book that will break your heart and mend it again.                                                                                                                                  |

 Challenging Read

 For the Reluctant Reader